Forsaken Friends

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Will-o'-Witch

There was a soft, lazy breeze, carrying nothing but the stuffy stench of the bog. It did wonders, sending chills down our sweat drenched spines, in this warm weather, and this forsaken situation.

But, it's work, and someone has to do it.

I look down on my muddied hands, and I push a small Willie in the jar with the others, making sure none of them manage to escape.

They're relatively easy critters, Willies. They wandered around the edges of these lands, and tried to lure people onto unstable grounds, to feast on the decomposing corpses left behind. There was one corpse too many, and I was contracted. And as long as I remember, to not focus my sight on them, too much, and not follow them around, it was just a matter of picking them from the air.

They were going to get killed, but fortunately for the little ones, they didn't really leave any body, so, to prove my deed, I had to bring them to the guild live. They'd be crushed and put out, there.

It was really stupid, that someone even got out here, and got caught by these critters. Everyone in any vicinity of the bog knew, to stay away from it. That it had a magic about it. Creatures not of the gods, and people who turned their backs to them, lived there. It was a dark, labyrinthine place, that no one who entered came back to tell tales of.

And yet, tales were plentiful. People talked about an ancient being, made of swamp, that guarded the land, and cursed anyone who dared to enter. They talked about weird lights and sounds that could be heard from the middle of the swamplands. I myself have heard the thunderous crowing, that came from there, on one of my trips hither.

No one dared to go into the land, among the trees and unstable terrain, and tales of terror. Nobody, except fools like the person that started my contract. Rest he in peace.

I needed one more Willie, and I'd have enough to finish the contract. I looked around for one more, and found it, at the edge of the treeline. Taking care to not look at it, too often, I made my way towards it. I focused mostly on the ground, to not sink too deep into the peat and mud.

Suddenly, a shadow hovered over me. I screamed, as a beastly, black talon grabbed hold of me, and I was flung into the air. I lost consciousness for a moment, and only got to, as my body hit the water of the swamp. The shadow was gone. There was a voice.

"You could have been a bit gentler with the boy, Morty."

There was no reply.

"I know he's here to kill our friends. I know he's a hunter. I'm just... too kind sometimes."

At this moment, I saw, out of the darkness, a tangle of branches, moss and mud emerge, with the face of a human woman. I shrieked at the sight, and tried to turn around to run, but found myself struggling against some vines in the water.

At that moment, she found her sight fixed to the jar in his hands. A big branch swung around, and crashed directly into the jar, shattering it, and causing all the 19 tightly packed Willies to fly out in all directions, in a mass of light. They started gently floating around, after a second, and disappeared into the forest. Then the figure faded back into the darkness.

I was pulling on the vines, and finally got my body free, when I noticed the forest ceiling closing up over me. After a few moments of me trying to to get out of the water, as the darkness was creeping in, I could no longer see anything at all.

I tried feeling my way, and tried walking straight through the swamp, in the direction I thought I had come from. I was giving up hope, thought I was as good as dead, but after a bit of blind wandering, I started seeing a bit of daylight shine through the thicket in front of me.

I walked forward, towards the light. Nothing else was important to me, anymore. I just needed to survive. I needed to get out of here.

Then, the daylight moved. It floated, slowly bobbing up and down, and drew closer to me. I stopped in my tracks. And noticed, I could not move any further. I was stuck, slowly sinking in the mud. The Willie illuminated my situation, allowing me to see, how I was nearly up to my knees in the ground. I had stepped right in.

I started praying for rescue.

I started praying for a quick death.

My mouth was slowly sinking under, and I could only breathe through my nose.

I could not breathe. The pain. The horror. All slowly fading.

Big Soup

The sun shone in, through the tall window. The beams moved slowly across the floor, harvesting what little colours the bleached carpet and tiles had, before reaching the bed. It had curtains, though they've been patched so many times, you could no longer recognize the original material. Though slow, the light was high in perseverance, and did not let the patchy curtains let it stop. It's beams reached the face of the person laying inside the mass of patched-up pillows and covers.

A groan signified, that the personage now slumping out of the comfort of a pillow nest has awakened.

There was a rhythmic, insistent scratching at the door. She looked up towards it, then groaned again. She went up to a small fountain, in the corner of the room, and splashed some water in her face. With a movement of her finger, some of the water coming out of the fountain momentarily turned into a surface of ice. She didn't have the best night, she realised, looking at the reflection, before the ice turned back into a misty splash of water, falling into the pool of the fountain.

"I know it's big soup day!," she said out loud. The scratching stopped. And then resumed, after a little bit of thought.

She sat back down on the bed, and combed her hair, then tied it into a neat ponytail. Then she finally got up, and opened the door.

On the other side of the door, stood a cauldron. It was cast to look, as if the legs were tiny little lion paws. One of them was missing. The front left one. At the front, there was a face, to look like a screaming or roaring lion, its mane spreading over the sides and bottom of the cauldron. There was a tear, a fracture, going down from the top of the front, all the way to the mouth of the lion, over one of its eyes. She had filled in the fracture with gold. She had heard, it was some ancient kind of magic. Not magic magic, but, thought magic. It changed how people look at things.

"Yes, Caul, we get to make big soup, today."

The cauldron hopped up, excitedly. Then it ran off, towards the kitchen.

"Garden first, today."

It instantly changed the direction it was running at, and zoomed past her, again.

The hallways were cool and empty, still. Other than the tapping of lead feeties on the tiles, it was quiet. The tiles were slightly warm, she felt through her soles. It always felt like this place was slightly alive.

After a short while, she arrived at the door to the backyard. Caul was already there, sat down beside it.

She grabbed the hat from the hanger just beside it, and went out.

The garden was in a state of ordered disarray. You can't really tell plants where to grow, if they don't really want to, after all. She looked into the shed, and took a knife from the worktop. She cut her index finger slightly, and let the blood drip into a carving she had made a couple of years ago. Then she conjured a few blocks of meat. She took them all, and cradling them in one hand, she took a bag of compost with the other.

She gave the bag of compost to Caul, who started taking its usual route through the garden, distributing it. She then went up to the corner of meat eating plants, who started turning towards her in interest. She threw a couple of the cubes at once, which the taller plants took no time to swallow up. She then cosied down to the smaller plants, and tore bits by bits of flesh off the cubes, to feed them.

By the time she was done, Caul had returned from its round, and they both went up to the epicenter of the vegetable part of the garden.

"Big Soup Day!," she yelled out in the garden.

The ground started vibrating, growing into a rumbling. Tiny hands sprung up from the soil below, and some of the vegetables started coming out. Roots and potatoes dug themselves out, while some tomatoes and beans started climbing down their vines. Some parts of herbs plucked themselves off, and started crawling on the ground. All of them, moving towards one point. They climbed up the sides, and jumped into Caul.

After the whole movement was over, and the earth was again still, she said: "Thank you."

She then went up to the big fruit tree, in the back of the garden, and sat down, leaning against it for a little bit. Caul joined her, by her side. A black cat also appeared from

behind the tree, and curled up in her lap. She reached into Caul, and the vegetables helped her grab the pillbox hiding in there.

She took one out, and put it up against the cat's mouth. The cat staggered a bit, but then opened their mouth, and swallowed the pill. She then pet the cat gently.

"So, how's the day been?"

"Nothing out of the ordinary happened," said the tree, "Humans came up to the edges of the swamp but they were too afraid to come in."

"Thank you about the report. How's your day been?"

"I'm always anxious, since everything that followed that day. But, it's been calm today. Thank you for helping keep that calm."

"Everyone deserves a safe space. I'm glad we can help each other with ours."

They sat, in silence, for a little while, the woman continuing to pet the black cat.

"So, big soup, today?" resumed the tree.

"Oh, ye, I should get on making that. Otherwise Caul might explode," she chuckled.

"Someone also left an offering at the northern hut."

"Thank you. I'll check on it, later. I hope you have a calm rest of your day."

"You'll hear from me, if it isn't," the tree said, with a lightly grave tone.

She moved the cat, stood up, and started on her way to the kitchen. At the door, she wiped her feet, and with a flick of her finger, got all of the dirt to fling back into the garden.

It was a bit of a longer way, to the kitchen, but the walk did her good. She was glad, that things were calm around here. She was curious, what brought the villagers to contact her, again. She tended to be a last option, and by choice.

At the kitchen, she let the vegetables climb out and up the counter, taking her own things out of Caul, and clicking a button, on a large machine in the corner. It dispensed large blocks of ice. She took two of them, and put them in Caul, who was already seating itself on top of the heat plate.

"Fire 8."

It took no magic, but the plate under Caul started glowing in a familiar reddish colour. The ice cubes began to slowly dissolve.

She suspected, that the machine might have been broken in some way, by the day that magic crashed. She wasn’t sure how, though. She just couldn’t imagine anyone needing blocks of ice this large, in a kitchen no less.

In the meantime, the vegetables were working on peeling and dicing themselves.

Soon enough, the water in Caul started boiling, and the veggies were ready to throw themselves in. She took one of the really big spoons, that were sitting on the counter, and started stirring, while the veggies jumped in, with glee. Tiny laughter was heard, and she could feel the magic evaporating from the vegetables, in Caul, and flowing back in the direction of the garden.

She took out some spices, that were in the cupboards around, and added them to the soup. The room was already filling with the smells of stock, of a hearty dinner.

She stirred some more, lost in thought, with Caul purring under her.

Caul and her were going up the stairs of the tower. It was the part of the building that was hit the most by the crash. There were some parts that were crumbled. Some places, where space was just not flowing right.

It mostly messed with her sense of balance, when she was sensing that she was walking on angled surfaces, while the actual walk went straight.

The reason why they were using the tower at all, was, because the top was mostly destroyed, to where Morty could have a sheltered place to sleep, that she could easily move in and out of. Morty made herself a nest there.

When they finally made it to the top, Morty was currently cleaning out her feathers. She was a giant crow, standing on one leg, and when she noticed the soup, she gobbled up her portion happily.

They sat around together, for a while, while Morty continued preening. The woman looked out the gaping hole in the walls, towards the sun, as it was slowly traveling over the forest, the warm rays lighting up her face.

The Curse

The sun was beaming straight down, but the winds of travel were giving her a nice cool. She had to hold fast to her hat, to not lose it, but she was used to it, by now. Under her, Caul was running, jumping and floating from tree to tree, making short work of the treacherous terrain that they were traversing. Theoretically, it could have just floated the whole way, but she assumed it was a lot more fun for it, this way.

She heard some frogs croak, heard some birds chirp and insects buzz, but at this speed, it was hard to take in the surroundings. She did enjoy seeing the forest from above. Seeing the land, as a whole. The green sea under her, with some brown and grey bits of swamp poking through. Today, it seemed calm. As calm as anything could seem, at the speed she was moving past it.

The hut was slightly outside of the swamp. It was a little run down, since she barely ever used it herself. She had a couple of them, laid out around the land, and they were mostly there, for people to be able to call her, if they needed help. If they needed a witch. They usually had to be very desperate, to call for her, and she didn’t want to deprive people in that situation from a way of contact.

It was illegal. Well, technically, it wasn’t directly illegal, to call her. But magic in general was outlawed, and anything magic related tended to be destroyed or killed. The swamp was just too dangerous and too far away, for anyone to order the guilds to get rid of them. The last time they tried, they lost many people, and obviously, the swamp is still here. So, the swamp was safe.

They reached the hut, and she immediately lit the hearth. Caul placed itself in the fire, and began purring gently. She conjured some water into it, and looked around the place. She found some tea leaves in one of the many jars lining the shelves, and threw them in. She found another, with a bit of honey, and added that, too. Then she asked Caul to turn into a kettle. It groaned slightly, but the metal soon started shifting.

The chimney smoke should be enough, for someone to arrive here soon. The kettle started roaring, and she poured herself a mug of tea, then lit a candle on the table, and placed Caul over it, to keep the tea warm for her guests. It started purring, again.

It took about an hour, before she heard a knock at the door. It was a pair of adults, with their child.

"We need your help, witch. We will pay any price," said the man.

"What is wrong with the boy?"

The man staggered for a second, then responded, "Our daughter is cursed. We do not know how to undo this, and we cannot go to any church with this. She has been unable to do most basic tasks, oft not getting out of bed to even eat food we provide for her. She's been behaving weirdly, and thinking of herself as a boy. We are sure it must be some forbidden magic, that has caused her to be so, cast on her by some neighbour, jealous of her femininity. If this continues, she shall surely be found out and killed, to contain the curse. We cannot let that happen."

"Give me a moment, with your daughter, then. It will involve magic, so it's best you stay out of it, for now."

The witch reached out her hand towards the kid. The parents, after a moment of hesitation, nudged the girl to follow the witch.

They both entered the hut, and the witch whirled her finger, making a bubble of air around the hut. Then she sat down at one side of the tea table, and gestured at the other seat, towards the girl. After they both were sitting down, she offered some tea, and looked at this daughter thoroughly.

First and foremost, she could not feel any magic, nefarious or otherwise around this person. She saw a pretty boy, an older teenager, and a deeply sad person. A husk of a person, unable to find what they need in this world.

"No one can hear us right now, and you can speak freely, if you want to. The good news is, you aren't cursed."

The kid's eyes lit up.

The witch continued:

"The bad news is, the feelings won't stop. They're not magical in nature. You feel like things are wrong, and, that's because things are wrong. But, it has nothing to do with curses, or magic, or anything that could be just easily fixed like that. That could be dispelled."

The kid’s whole body dropped slightly, and they curled up. The witch stopped a little, and took a sip of her tea. The boy didn’t deserve all the pain that was coming his way, she thought.

"And what’s worse, what you’re going through, might kill you, in many ways. One way being, if you continue doing nothing. You won’t feel better. Slowly, you might start losing hope. And a person without hope is not a person for this world, for long."

The witch started seeing a tear, in the kid’s eyes.

"And the second being, even though it isn’t magic, it will still be considered that, by the churches. You are not safe from them. They will try to destroy you, to contain that ’curse’."

"What the fuck can I do, then?" cried the kid.

"You can ask for help. It comes at a price, however," calmly said the witch.

They looked at each other, while the tears were still flowing down the kid’s face. The witch’s face in turn looked back, full of commiseration.

"Who are you? Are you a girl? Are you a boy? Are you something entirely else?" asked the witch, suddenly.

The kid jolted in confusion, at the question.

"Of course I’m a girl! I’ve always been a girl! I got cursed by these unnatural thoughts!"

"Ok, the I shall treat you as such. But know, that you are certainly not cursed. That nothing that’s happening to you is unnatural. It’s as old as humanity itself."

"I offer you protection, girl. I offer you help with avoiding your death. But, you are a magical creature now. You are something others will want to hunt and kill. My protection would mean, you cannot live with your family, with your friends. I cannot protect you from afar. And I cannot live among them. Neither of us can, if we want to live, not for long."

The girl started crying even harder.

"I don’t expect certainty of you. You can change your mind, at some point. You can try to live the way you have lived, and see if it works for you after all. You can come with me, and figure out if that’s ok with you, and if it isn’t, return home, forget about it, and live the rest of your life out among family and friends."

The girl needed a break from all the information coming her way, assumed the witch. She gave another pause, sipping at the rest of her tea. She needed a hug, the witch thought. But not from the witch.

After a bit of the silence of wails and tears, the elder woman resumed:

"Lastly, I just want to say, that what you're dealing with, is not impossible to do something about. If I'm right about what you're dealing with. There are ways to help, against the feeling of not being a boy."

"You horrible temptress!" -the girl screamed through her tears- "You vile witch! I shall break this curse by myself, if I have to, but I will not believe any word of what you said. No one is out to get me, and the thoughts will pass. Maybe you're the one sending them to me, yourself!"

She stormed out of the hut, leaving her unfinished tea, and popping the air-bubble. She found her parents, sitting on the grass, not far away.

"That witch will not help us or me in any way. She is a charlatan. I will break the curse myself, if I have to. Let's leave this unholy place, as fast as we can."

And so, the witch looked on, as they left towards the road, towards their village. She wished that girl well. She hoped, for her sake, that she figured things out for herself. She poured the rest of the tea out into the fireplace, and rinsed Caul out. Then, getting Caul to be his regular form again, she stepped in, and started the ride back into the swamp.

When they reached back home, she went to the library, and looked for a very specific book. It's been a while since she did some potion brewing, but she knew she had the recipe she was looking for, somewhere in there. When she finally found the book she was looking for, a white tome, full of chemical knowledge, she took it over to the laboratory she had, and started reading through.

It took a while, but by the evening, the bubbling of flasks and hissing of burners could be heard from the lab.

To be Fair

Darkness gave way to consciousness, as he started feeling the bed below him, again. Imprinted in the bed was his form, his body, his suffering. He tried not to move around, so he wouldn’t have to feel the rest of his parts move about, bringing him anguish.

He did not know what he had done, to deserve this curse. Why he hated his bits so much, and why every movement, every sight, was repulsive.

But she was a girl. She couldn’t let the curse win. She propped herself up, on the bed, feeling those forsaken meatbags move with her. She stood up and changed into her work clothes, which were fortunately hand-me-downs from her older brother, and thus didn’t trigger any bad feelings. She left the strips of fabric, that she used to fasten her breasts, alone, though. She just needed to get used to them.

She was regretting that choice, going down the stairs, towards the main room of the house. Her breathing started becoming shallower, her mind focusing on every single bounce her body was going through. By the time she felt she was gasping slightly, she turned around, and got back into her room. She closed her eyes, and sat still on the bed, until she was calm.

She took of her shirt, and bandaged up her breasts, until she had them stable enough not to feel them when she hopped. Then, with her shirt back on, she moved back down, to the main room.

Father and mother were talking about something to the eldest. She thought she caught some words about going into town for a trade or deal. Either way, she didn’t want to be seen by people, today, so she just snuck out the front door. There were some apple trees growing around their home, and she picked a riper looking one, as a breakfast for on the road.

Moving away from home, she followed the field-paths and streams, towards the grassy hill. She came here, often. He would just lay down in the grass, and listen into all the sounds of nature around him. It felt as if he dissolved, then, no longer had to focus on himself and his body. He wanted to feel that, right now. His mind was too clouded, and he needed a rest.

He started hearing a voice, a while after laying down in the comforting grass. It seemed like a boy... No, a couple of boys were closing in on his location. He laid prone in the taller grass, and waited, unhappy to have had his alone time interrupted.

Soon enough, he noticed two boys and a girl from the nearby village, and as they grew closer, he recognised them. He stood up hastily, and started running away, back the way he came from. The group spotted him, and started running after him, shouting after her to stop, and saying things like "boy-girl", and worse.

He knew them, as the people who'd throw things at him, when he was in town, and derided his looks. He looked back, with tears welling in his eyes, to see if they were getting any closer to him, but, it seems they have given up. He continued on the way back, rapidly, only to hear a thump, as a rock landed a bit to the left of him. Then he felt a prick, and a blooming flower of pain on his left shoulder, from what thankfully was a smaller rock. After that, he had outrun anything else.

He arrived back home, wiped away his tears, and tried sneaking back to his room, but was caught by his father.

"Go get your mother to make you look presentable. Why do you keep dressing up like this?" he scolded her. "I want you ready in ten minutes. We're going into town."

She slumped towards the room her mother was residing in, and relayed the message. After that, was a blur of changing into "presentable" clothes, which just meant a dress, her mother cleaning and combing her hair, and a touch from her mum's makeup bag. She steeled herself throughout the whole ordeal and ignored most of the words said to her, through the duration of it. Most of it was about how she should learn to show off her perks, more. A bit, was being outraged, that she's coming home with bruises.

Last of all, she finally answered why the girl was being made up at all.

"Father and I have talked, since we got back from the witch. We know it's sudden, but decided, what we could do to help you, was putting you into the life of a woman, where you would have to learn how to be fair. We're going out today, to have you meet a gentleman who'd be interested in taking you as his wife."

"I understand, mother," she numbly answered.

At this point of the day, she was turned off. She just went through the motions of life, trying her best to not feel much more discomfort.

They set out into town. The walk was not comfortable. She did not want to be used to walking around in a dress, and hated walking around without the fabric around her breasts. She felt like her body was bloated and bulging in every direction, fighting against her wear.

There was a merchant’s house, tall and broad, near the center of the town. It seemed to be their destination, when her father knocked on the entrance door. It was a sturdy, heavy door, and it took a moment for a person to heave it ajar.

A manservant welcomed them into the house. Focused on her body, and her dress, she didn’t really take much of the inside in. She got snapped back into the external, when her mother pushed her head down, gesturing towards her to curtsy. There was a boy there. He was a bit older than her, dressed in fashionable clothes. He looked slightly like a puffed up bird, ruffling his feathers. She noticed his gaze was directed at her. She did not like the look in his eyes. She did not like the her that was reflected in them.

She nodded politely, said yes and no at times, and let the whole world flow away around her. The conversation didn’t exist. She didn’t exist. All there was was the slight pressure of the stream of time against her mind.

She was jolted, again, as the boy came up to her and asked to take her hand. She didn’t know what to say.

Her mother noticed her directionless gaze, and nodded towards her. She said yes.

Everyone started looking back at the two men in the room, who shook hands, smiling.

She faded away, again. She could do nothing else, if she wanted to be comfortable.

In her mind, she went back to the talk she had with the witch. She asked herself who she was. If she was a wife to a boy she had just met. If she was the girl the boy wanted her to be. The girl her parents wanted her to be. A girl at all.

It got late, they started going home. People around him were congratulating him, and talking about preparations. He smiled and nodded, shook hands with people, and let everything pass by. The walk back was marred by her father’s slightly drunk talk. There must have been alcohol involved in the evening. She hadn’t noticed. He took step after step, one by one, focusing on nothing, thinking about nothing.

There was his house. He stepped in, went up the stairs, and closed his door behind him. He quietly, calmly took of his

dress, and all of his garments. He stood there, for a second, then fell to his knees.

He cried.

Tears

"The human has arrived at the hut", the tree noted.

"Thank you, Ruth. I'll get going, then", the witch responded.

She gave the tree a gentle kiss, and moved towards her room, to grab some clothes. On the way there, she yelled out for Caul, who soon enough was trotting next to her.

Garbed and ready, she slid into the night with her trusty companion. Wind blew through her hair, as Caul rushed through the treetops towards were the girl was waiting.

The house was empty, when he arrived there, as usual. He hoped it was enough of a sign, for him to be there. So far, every time someone visited, the witch would soon after come. He sat down in one of the chairs, but soon enough stood back up, and paced around the place. He looked over the jars, lining the walls. Lots of herbs and spices, and some other plants he didn't all recognise. His heart was racing, as he read over the labels, trying to distract himself.

He was doing rounds, in the single room of the hut. Staying still seemed impossible. He felt he shouldn't be here. He felt he was making a mistake. He also felt he had nowhere else he could be. The night was deep, and the next day loomed over him, with it's promises of a life not worth living. He kept imagining seeing the light of morning over the horizon, a sign of things he did not wish to come. He shuttered the window.

He sat down in one of the chairs, again, and started tapping his foot. Looking over towards the hearth, he thought of maybe lighting it, maybe making himself something warm, to pass the time. There was still some dry wood stapled next to it, and he fount the flintstone rather quickly. There wasn't really any pots around, that he could find, so he gave up on that idea. He sat back down, leaning against the table. Some light drumming on the table commenced.

As they drew closer to the hut, she noticed lights in the vicinity. Along the ground, flames illuminated the torches and the hands that held them, all filing in the direction of the thatched building.

Caul touched ground still in the darkness, near the door. She hopped out, and ran in, to see a half-asleep kid, sitting at the table. She shook the kid awake.

"Why did you come?" she asked, sternly.

"What did you do?!" she added, a bit louder, before the kid managed to say anything.

"I ran away," the kid murmured, "I need help."

After a moment of trying to bring their head to some clarity, the kid added: "I need time."

"I'll help. Follow me," she stated, shortly and nervously, then took the kid's hand, and got outside.

The crowd had arrived. At the front, she could recognise the kid's parents.

"What brings you here, people?" She tried to sound confident.

"You took our daughter!" the father yelled at her, and the crowd murmur grew louder.

"She came to me, for shelter," she answered.

"She escaped your grasp, before. It must be a hex you put upon her. It was a mistake, to ever ask you for help." His sadness and anger welled in his speech. "Leave my daughter, and be gone, lest we kill you!"

The witch turned back, towards the kid. She asked: "Do you want to stay, or come with me?"

"I need time," the kid whimpered, near tears.

"That's not an answer. That's not a choice."

"Come... with you."

The crowd was closing the distance, and pointing their torches towards the witch and her hut. With a smooth movement of her arm, a sheet of water materialised over the first rows, shocking the people, and putting out some of the torches. The kid's mother started running towards her child. The father ripped a still burning torch from another person's hand, and threw it at the witch. There were screams all around. The witch grabbed the kid at their upper arm, and pulled them, hopping into Caul. A torch hit the house behind them, spreading sparks over the dry wall and roof. The witch looked a last time towards the hut, a sea of flames reflecting in the window. Caul jumped into the air. Screams erupted, a few torches were heaved towards

them, but the distance made that effort futile. The kid screamed: "I'll be back.", while looking down, at the glistening tears on his mother's face.

The windows of the hut were smashed in. Fire was laid at the base, as the roof was already beginning to smoke.

From over the forest, the witch watched the pyre lighting the night ablaze.

"Fuck! My heart is pounding! What the hell was that?!" the witch yelled, at no one in particular.

"They found out I was missing. They went out to look for me," the kid noted.

"That did not look like a search party."

The rest of the travel went relatively quietly, but for the wind, and the sniffling of the kid.

Bonds

When they arrived at the fortress, deep in the forest, the first light of morning was beginning to shine through the treetops. The sleepy eyes of the fortress windows followed them in their gentle descent. Caul's feet touched ground on one of the walls, not far from the witch's room. She gently pet its brim, and stepped out, then held out her hand, to help the kid out as well.

The kid didn't really react. She motioned Caul to follow her, and started down the stairs, into the corridors of her home. It didn't seem like the pulsating warmth and gentle wind flowing through the insides of the fortress were of much comfort to her companion, as they eventually arrived at an empty room. With Caul's help, she managed to heave the kid's body out of it, and onto the bed. The kid did not resist. She thought about if gentle touch might be comforting to the kid, and decided against it. Not yet. Not from her. She just said: "You're safe, now.", and sat down on the chair, at the dressing table in the corner of the room. Caul went up to her, and nudged her leg with its face.

"It's gonna be ok, Caul. I'll just rest here. I hope having someone there will be more comfort than harm."

Caul circled around, then looked up at her. Then, as far as a cauldron can curl up, curled up at her side.

A weight was in her lap. She looked down, and gently pet the black cat now providing her with some warmth. The kid was still sobbing, lightly. She wished she could help. But for now, the kid needed time.

It was two days since the kid arrived at the castle. She brought them food, and stayed by their side. They seemed empty. Didn't say a word. But they ate, and drank, when offered. That was enough, for now. They slept a lot. She had tried to talk, but it's hard to keep conversation going, without any answers.

They were blank, but didn't really resist. She tried to get the kid to walk around the castle with her. They went to the

garden, where she introduced Rutaceae to the kid. Ruth was concerned, but the kid was indifferent. They met up with the hivemind, and saw Caul and Grim here and there. Going up to the tower was a struggle, with her having to hold the kid fast, and watch both their step, to not stumble constantly. They rested in Morty’s plumage, gazing at the vast swathes of forest visible from this vantage point.

And eventually, she got the kid back to bed, where they lay, without much sign of life.

"What am I doing here?"

She nearly jumped, at the sound. She turned around, to see the kid, sitting at the edge of their bed, looking vaguely at her.

"What?", she eloquently replied.

"What am I doing here?", the kid asked.

"You asked me for time. I’m giving you time."

Tears welled up in the eyes of the kid. Then they streamed forth, in a glittering pour.

"Do you...-", she wasn’t sure if she should be asking, "Do you want a hug?"

There was no answer, through the sobs.

"Look, kid. I’m not really good at humans. You’re gonna have to work with me a little, here. I’m already really glad you’re talking, but I’m really out of my depth."

She touched the kid’s shoulder with her palm. They didn’t resist. They didn’t react. She wasn’t sure how to take it. She gently patted their shoulder.

She stood there, by their side, until the pour dried out.

"Nothing you don’t want will happen here," she cooed.

Later that day, when she brought the kid a meal, she got a thank you in return.

It was the next morning, bringing them some breakfast, that she noted the kid looking a bit livelier.

"How are you feeling, today, girl?" She noted the shudder on the kid, when she said that.

"Sad. But, a bit better. I’m trying not to think about it."

"About "it"?", she asked.

"Most everything that’s been happening," the kid said, dryly.

They sat, in silence, for a moment, the kid prodding some of their food with their fork.

"Wanna help me with some chores, today?", the witch proposed.

"Beats sitting in bed, all day."

She smiled hearing that.

"Just one question. Why are you naked?"

"Why would I need clothes?", she asknswered.

"Huh." The kid was uncertain. "Can I keep mine?"

"Feel free to, kid. To each their own."

"Huh."

They got up, and moved out of the room, together.

There wasn’t that much to help with, in the castle. everything worked pretty seamlessly. The witch herself didn’t really have to do much. She let the kid throw some of the flesh cubes, to the carnivorous plants. She took the sheets from both their bedrooms, and with Caul’s help, they set out to clean them, after which the kid helped her hang them up to dry, as well as fitting other ones back on the beds. She found some clothes that fit dubiously right, on the kid, so that his clothes could get a freshening up, as well. Then they got to the kitchen together to cook.

They made the rounds, to everyone in the castle, with what they managed to cook up. Then the kid was free to do whatever they wanted. They joined the witch, sitting under the great fruit tree, in the middle of the courtyard garden. As the evening closed, the witch excused herself, and let Ruth, Grim and the kid there, to bask in the fading sun. The kid pet the cat gently, and when the last rays of light disappeared behind the castle wall, they went back to their room.

Laying in bed, he thought about how it was he was feeling. It wasn’t right. It wasn’t good. But he escaped a fate he couldn’t bear. But he also lost so much because of that. So many. But is there even anything he could do, anything he could change? He drifted off to sleep, his head clouded by thoughts of what could have happened, and his uncertain future, turning his dreams towards unease.

Grimalkin

It was a summer afternoon, and the sounds of the stream were flowing all around the bridge. The dirt road wound gently through the grassy plains, skipping over in stone, only where the water wouldn’t let it otherwise. Under one of the sparse trees populating the landscape, in the shade, lay a boy, chewing on a piece of grass.

"Wha’chu got there?", he asked, seeing two familiar, young figures approaching him, a burlap sack dragged between them.

The sack groaned. One of the boys dragging it kicked the side, which elicited a yelp.

"A critter, John," said the other boy excitedly, "I think it might be one of those fairies."

John sat up, hearing that, and looked, big-eyed, at the sack. He propped himself up, and one of the boys held out his hand, to help him on his feet. Then he opened up the sack.

"That’s just a cat." His posture drooped.

"Peter saw the cat disappear before his eyes, and appear further down the road moments later," the non-Peter boy explained.

"I think both of you are full of shit, is what it is." John spat down. "If it can just disappear, Dave, then why is it still in the sack?"

"It gave up," offered Peter.

"Well, no use letting the cat out of the bag, now." John smiled to himself, as he tied the sack back up. A pathetic meow came from the inside. "Lets throw it in the water. If it is magic, it’ll escape, and we can deal with it, then."

The boys nodded to each other. John took up the back end of the bag, and helped Peter and Dave carry it up to the bridge and onto the railing.

"What are you boys doing?!," came a stern voice from down the road.

The trio turned around, to see a gangly, pale woman, clad in a black robe, with a wide brimmed black hat, striding towards them.

"What do you care, granny?," John sneered, and gave the bag a shove.

The dark figure rapidly stretched out an arm, still moving towards the bridge. Peter looked down over the railing.

"It's fucking floating!" He looked over at the woman that was growing ever closer. "She's a witch!"

It took the wide-eyed boys a moment, but they all came to a simultaneous conclusion, and bolted.

The witch stopped on the road, and had to focus. She felt the bag slipping from her. Magic here was too weak, too sparse. A quiet "Fuck." escaped her lips, and there was a plop, of burlap and fur submerging. She ran on, to where she thought the sack.

At the side of the stream, she saw the sack floating down with the current, scraping against the bottom of the stream-bed. She hopped in, and waded through, until she was close enough to pull the bag towards shore. She heaved the bag out of the water, and went about untying it, all the while cussing out the boys that had caused this.

"Scoundrels! Malfeasants! Wastrels!"

Finally, she managed to drag the cat out of the bag. It started coughing, and vomiting up water. She moved her hands over it, and heated up the air around it, letting it dry and getting its body temperature to normal. Then it wasn't there, anymore.

She looked around. She felt the tear. It didn't lead far away. She wrung out her robe, gave it a whoosh of heat, and climbed back up to the road, in the middle of which she found the cat.

"I'm trying to help," she said, "We shouldn't dilly-dally. There might just be people coming with pitchforks, soon."

The cat continued laying in the middle of the road, still coughing a little. She went up to it, and picked it up, but it wasn't in her hands. She turned around, to find it behind her, in the middle of the road.

"They will kill you, when they find out what you are. They tried to, not even knowing. You're not safe, here."

She grabbed at it, again, felt it's fur against her skin, pulled the weight up, but her hands just flung into the air, with the weight that wasn't there.

"Let." She grabbed at it again. "Me." And again. "Help." Again. "You."

She sat down on the road, frustrated, with the cat still curled up, not far away from her.

"Do you want to die?"

A quiet meow was her answer.

"Well, I'm not letting you."

Another meow.

"Look, I know life can be shit. I don't know what you went through. I don't know what made you feel like this. But it's not over. You're not over. I'm not letting you. It's gonna get better, and you'll get dragged to the better, willing or screaming."

There was no answer.

She started working. She didn't have much to work with, the magic here was really sparse, but she began visualising a wall, a circle, a sphere. A ward, but inverted. It was weird, with things that were pure magic. That were not elements she could touch and feel. This was just space, but not even that. A lock on space. A sort of protection. The feeling, the anxiety of being locked, the feeling, the safety of being protected. The idea. And then it was there. She hoped it would hold. It would get better, as they moved closer to her home. To where magic was stronger.

She picked up the cat. It was still there, in her arms. It groaned in protest, and maybe pain. She let it rest on her arm, and coddled it to her chest. Then got on the way. Her plans would have to change. Getting the cat to safety, now, was the priority.

Roots

"So, kid." She sat down at the edge of the kid's bed. The gently pulsating warmth of the floor stones was comforting to her. She let her feet glide across them, feeling the smoothness and the irregularities. The kid was still under their covers, but sat up, looking at her lazily. "Last time I asked, you insisted I call you a girl." This drew a short tremble in the kid's form, and a snort, from the witch.

"A lot of things have happened since then. A lot of things are different. Is there any change in how you'd like me to refer to you?"

"I don't really wanna think about it." The kid averted their gaze from her.

"Look, kid. You've been here a week, already. I don't even know your name."

"I don't know yours either. It's never been a problem," they scowled.

"You literally shudder, every time I call you a girl."

"I really don't want to think about it!," they shouted.

"Okay, kid." She pushed herself up from the bed, and refound her balance. "It's Jagoda, by the way." She stretched out her hand, towards the kid.

"That doesn't sound like a real name. But sure, granny." The kid took the outstretched hand in theirs. They squeezed, gently, and then she helped them get out of the bed.

"What the fuck do you mean, by 'granny'?!" She jabbed the kid in the belly. "I'm not old enough to be a granny."

"I'm old enough not to be a kid," the kid smirked at her, "You must be ancient."

They walked together, through the winding corridors, until they reached a room with a large table at the center. They sat down, where the witch had previously set their breakfast, and jointly ate.

"I wanted to grab some of my things, from home. See my mother and sister, again."

"You just gotta tell Caul or Morty. They'll take you there, whenever you want. How much do you want to bring?"

"Not much, just some clothes, toys and books."

"Nothing too heavy? If you want to grab something heavier, it's probably better to talk to Caul."

"No, but, Caul is probably less conspicuous, either way. How does one... talk to him?"

The witch smiled. "You talk to it how you talk to anyone, kid. It has its ways of talking back."

"Ok...?" The kid was uncertain, but didn't ask more questions.

"Do you want me to come with you? Last time we were there, they came with torches and burned my hut down."

"I think it might be safer, if I just go alone. I don't know if clearing up that you didn't kidnap me would be too easy."

"I hope things go well for you, then. Take as much time as you need." She pat the kid's head, at which they scoffed.

"I'm not a child. Stop that, granny."

They finished up their food, and the kid went off, looking for Caul. The witch moved slowly towards the garden. She sat down, under Ruth, and leaned against her.

"How are you doing, Rutie?"

"Same as always, Jadzia. Slightly anxious. Better, when you're here."

"Aw, you hopeless romantic," the witch smiled, "So, nothing out of the ordinary is happening, around."

"No. Nothing I can sense."

"We're going to be safe, here. I'll make sure of it, Rutie."

"I know... It's just. You know."

"I know," the witch held a hand up against the bark, "I'll always be here with you."

The tree laughed, in a sad cadence. "Always is a long time."

"Shush, you party-pooper. I'll be here with you. We'll be together. Taking care of everyone that needs it. Including each other."

"I love you, Jadzia."

"I love you, too, my sappy girl."

They sat there, pressed against each other, enjoying each other’s presence, each other’s touch.

The cat was there, sitting up next to her.

"I’ve been waiting for you," the witch said, calmly, "Have you taken your medicine, yet?"

There, in her hand, was a pill.

"I see. You’re pretty spoiled, aren’t you. Open your mouth."

She fed the cat the pill. And pet its head, after it swallowed.

"I had something to ask of you, actually, Grim."

The cat tilted its head to the side.

"The kid is going home, today. Just wanted to ask if you could keep an eye on them. Make sure they’re safe, today."

The cat meowed, then walked in a small circle. Then it wasn’t there.

"Who’s the worry-wart, now," chimed in the tree.

"Pretty sure you’re worried, too," playfully jabbed back the witch.

"You wouldn’t love me, if I wasn’t myself."

"Worry is not yourself, Ruth. Care is. I know you worry because you care, but, I would still love you, if you didn’t have things to worry about."

There was a moment of silence, between them.

"And, you know," smirked the witch, "You’re cute when you’re relaxed."

"So I’m not cute when I’m anxious?," playfully noted the tree.

"You, my love, are always cute. Whether you want to or not," exclaimed the witch, "So you’re also cute, when you’re relaxed."

She gave the tree a little peck. Then they just lay there, against each other, skin against bark.

A Hop Away

The kid was walking down the warm, dark corridors of the castle. It still felt weird to him, walking through here. The pulsating heat of the stone. The feeling like when he wasn’t looking, the walls were contracting and expanding. It felt like there was a slow rhythm, filling the whole build. Granny seemed to be completely unaware of it, or at least, used to it.

And this. He never really knew where he was going, he always felt, like he was lost in this tangle of hallways. But he always made it, to where he wanted to go. It was hard to explain. He found Caul. Or rather, he found that Caul was just currently strolling down the corridor crossing where he randomly landed.

"Hey, Caul?," he projected at it.

It looked back, and then casually strutted up to him.

"I wanted to grab some things from home. Talk to my mum. Could you take me there?"

Caul hopped. Then the kid followed it up, towards some stairs that led to the ramparts. A cat was with them, going up the stairs.

Caul waited on the castle wall, looking at them. It took the kid a moment, but he assumed it wanted him to get in, now. He carefully stepped over the brim of the cauldron, and into it. He only noticed the cat there with him, when it jumped in as well.

"What are you doing here, Grim?"

There wasn’t much of an answer, with Caul taking off suddenly. They just both held on, as the wind and the land beneath them passed them by, rapidly.

They landed in a wood he knew. He had played and relaxed here, plenty a time before. Caul let him out. The cat wasn’t there. He took a few steps in the direction of the village. He looked back. Caul wasn’t following him.

"You’re not coming with me?"

Caul shook its body.

"Ye, I suppose that makes sense," the kid coyly smiled at it.

He waved at Caul, and Caul waved back with one of its paws. Then he went on, towards his home.

The road was relatively bereft of people, on his way back. There was only one group, but he heard them from far away, and gave them a wide berth. Soon enough he arrived on their land. He went by one of the apple trees growing around, and picked one that looked ripe enough. The door to the home was open, as usual, so he just let himself in. He made his way upstairs, and checked in his room. It seemed about the same as he left it, still. He went about, getting his things together.

"Sis!? You're alive!" He heard the shout of his little sister, from behind, before feeling the weight of her body flung at him, in a hug. He turned around, and then picked his sister up, swirling her around.

"Of course I'm alive. Why wouldn't I be?"

There was the sound of footsteps, running up the stairs. He looked to the door, where a somewhat out of breath, and shocked figure of his mother appeared.

"You!," she started.

"You're dead!," she stated.

"We had a funeral," she explained.

"I said I'd be back, mum."

His mother threw herself into the hug, teary eyed, together with the both of them.

"How did you escape the witch?"

"I'm not...," he started.

His mother took a big step back, from him, pulling his sister along with her.

"I'm not well, yet. I still need some time, to figure things out."

"You're not going away, again, are you, sis?" His little sister looked at him, with big, watery eyes.

He stepped up towards them, but his mum blocked his way to the sister.

"I have to. I can get help, there. It's not going to be forever."

"Please, don't die again, sis," sobbed his little sister.

"You're not going to go anywhere, Madison," exclaimed his mum. standing in the way of the door. "Your father will be here, soon, and you'll be safe with us. We'll fix you."

"I'm not Madison! I'm not your daughter, mum!," he shouted back.

"You can't help me, here," he said, more resigned. "This is something I have to figure out for myself. Everything that we tried, to help, has hurt me so much."

"You don't know what's good for you. We'll call a priest. We will get rid of the curse. We'll find a way."

There was a cat, between them, hissing. He looked over at it, and it looked back at him. He stepped up, and crouched down to his sister. He cupped her face in his hand, and whisked a tear away. He looked her in the eyes and said: "I'll be back."

Then he stepped back and took the bundle he had readied on his bed.

"What do you think you're doing?," shouted his mother.

The cat hissed at her. Then, it wasn't there. Neither was he.

He was in the woods. He stumbled, and fell over. Laying on the ground, he noticed the cat, that was standing next to him.

"I didn't know you could do that."

The cat meowed.

"I know, but, me too? And all of my things?"

The cat licked it's paw, then purred.

"I would have just gotten out the window. I've done that plenty before."

He got up, from the ground.

"Thank you, Grim. Warn me next time, though." The kid smiled at the cat.

Caul was not too far off. It was scratching at a tree, as a squirrel looked victoriously from up above. When it noticed them walking up, it ran in a circle for a moment, then got up to them. The kid put his bundle of things inside of it. The cat was already on top of the bundle, and pressed on it with its paws, to knead it to comfort. He stepped in, as well. And off they went, flying into the air, leaving behind naught but a very confused and concerned squirrel.

Binding

The witch was in the process of setting supper, when a cat hopped onto the chair next to where she, at that moment, was.

"Oh. You're back, already?"

A meow answered her.

She went out, to grab another three sets of food.

The kid hopped out of Caul, onto the cut stone of the ramparts. He picked up his bundle, thanked Caul, and noted that Grim wasn't there, anymore. He made his way downstairs, and towards his room.

He spread his bundle out, over his bed. Most of the clothes he cared about. A book he hasn't finished, and two he hasn't started. A few knickknacks of his, like an ring he got from a friend, when they were little, now too small for his fingers, a piece of chalk he would sometimes doodle with, and a pretty looking red stone, glittering slightly under the light. A stitched-together mishmash of fabrics and stuffing, in the shape of a platybara. A vague shape between a platypus and a capybara. He didn't sleep with it, anymore, but it was never far away. He put that on the nightstand, next to his bed, and started to put away his clothes.

The witch leaned against his doorway, as he was finishing up putting everything in its place.

"How did it go?," she asked.

"I don't know. Bad. But better? I don't know." He looked down at the floor, hoping it might tell him, if what he was doing was right. It didn't answer. "I'll just... figure things out. And then I can be back with them."

"You have time," she answered, into the room, "Speaking of, the food is getting cold. Do you need any help unpacking?"

"It's not too much stuff, I'm pretty much done, already."

"I'll be waiting in the dining room, then."

Caul was standing on a chair, and Grim was sitting on the table, next to a bowl. There was a free spot for him, just next to granny. He sat down, and started eating. The witch scooped out a bowl of the curry into Caul, then joined in as well, on her portion.

"I saw you brought some books with you," she started.

"The Adventures of Alexander of Mansus."

"What's it about?"

"Great loves, great tragedies. Death, betrayal, violence and murder. The book I'm reading right now has him grieving over his lover's death, not knowing that she's not dead, and it's all a plot by his long lost brother, to drive him out of the country and take his place," he excitedly offered. "He's just at the cusp of figuring it out. I cannot wait to read his surprise, when he finds out not only his lover, but also his brother are still alive."

"I hope it continues to be just exciting, then", the witch smiled. "If you run out of books, there is a library in the castle. It's mostly textbooks, but there should be some fiction around, as well."

The kid's eyes perked up at the news of this.

"Any adventure stories?," he proposed.

"I'm sure we'll find something daring enough, for you, kid," the witch said, grinning. "I can take you there, after we've cleaned up after supper."

"Deal, granny."

They opened the large door, and entered the library. It was an expansive hall, with rows of shelves, each of them tightly packed with rows of books. At the front, there was a large table, and in the corner were some armchairs. The large windows high up on the walls lit up the room well.

"It seems to have some sort of system, by which the books are organised," the witch said. "But I'm still not really sure what it is. It seems like books on similar subjects are close together, though. I've been putting books back from where I got them, to not disturb that. Hope you keep it that way, too."

The kid went among the shelves, and looked at the titles displayed on the spines. Flowery texts, alchemical knowledge, charts and maps. As he neared the back, he found what he was looking for: Stories. There were two and a bit shelves, filled with them, of varying genres, in various shapes and sizes. They

were all covered in a layer of dust, just like most of the books around.

He returned to the front with a black book in hand.

"Found something you like?," the witch asked.

The kid nodded. "I still have others left to read, but it looks enticing."

A week has passed. The kid spent these days helping with chores, chatting with the witch or the tree, and mostly reading through his stories.

The witch knocked on his door. He came up to, and opened it.

"Can I come in?," she asked.

"You're welcome," he said, sitting back down on his bed.

She picked up a chair, and brought it over closer, then sat down as well.

"You've been bandaging up your breasts," she stated.

He looked away from her.

"That's not safe," she continued.

"I can't deal with them. It's all I can do."

"It could seriously hurt you, in ways that have nothing to do with your chest. And it could, in ways that will make your chest feel worse."

"I don't have any choice!," he shouted out.

They sat, in silence, for a while.

"I can try to sew something up for you," she said. "It's not going to be perfect, and it won't make your chest disappear, but, it should be safer. I'll try to work quickly. Until then, would it be ok, if you didn't wear any bandages?"

"I don't think I can do that."

"Loosen them, at least?," she pleaded with him. "Wait here, in bed."

She ran out of the room, and disappeared in the castle corridors. Soon though, she was back, with some tape in hand.

"Stand up," she ordered.

She pulled him up, and took a few measurements of his chest and shoulders.

"I need you to take off the bandage, for a moment, as well."

"No," he stated.

She looked him over, again, but decided not to push it. Then she strode out of the room, again.

He propped himself up and waited. After a while of her not coming back, he tugged at the bandage under his shirt. He unwound it, and took a deep breath. It was hard to take more than a shallow breath, with it on. He reapplied it, but a bit looser, not pushing everything in as much. To turn his mind away from his body, he picked up the book on his nightstand, and continued reading it.

The sun has moved quite a bit across the sky, by the time the witch returned to the kid’s room. She was holding some kind of vest, which she threw into the kid’s lap.

"Get your bandages off. Try this," she imposed.

He looked at her, naked as she was.

"Could you turn around?"

"I won’t eat you," she sighed, but turned around.

A bit of scuffling around later, the voice from behind her came: "I guess it’s better than nothing."

"It should fit snugly, and keep your chest out of your way. It’s stretchy, to let you breathe. You still shouldn’t wear it all the time."

The kid breathed in deeply, then out again. Then he shook his upper body a bit.

"I can’t promise that. You can turn around, if you want to."

She looked back at him, the bandage coiled up at his side.

"You really hate your body, don’t you?," she put out there.

He looked at her for a while, in thought.

"It’s not really hate. It’s discomfort. It’s wrong. It makes me panic. It’s things I try not too think about, really hard."

"Do you know what could make you feel better?"

"Do you have any propositions?"

"Not really. I’m happy with my body the way it is. I like it. But you don’t. Do you have any ideas about what would be more to your liking?"

"It’s a lot of flabby meat. Jiggling curves I wish I did not have."

"If you somehow managed to get rid of your boobs, would you be happy?"

"I don’t know. Happier for sure. But I’d still be myself."

"Suffering isn’t yourself, kid. When you imagine yourself happy, what do you see?"

"Myself, relaxing in a meadow, listening to the wind."

"And who are you, being there, in the meadow?"

"I don’t know." He started retreating in his bed.

"Whoever you is, the happy you, we need to find them. You can’t just live with this eating you from the inside. But we have time. You have time."

The witch looked over at the kid. She sighed, lightly.

"How is the story going?," she asked, with a gentle smile.

Colour flashed up again in the kid’s eyes.

"Alexander is in a sword fight with his evil brother, on the castle walls. He has managed to save his love, but he has not yet found out his relation to the man he’s fighting. They’re pretty evenly matched, but I’m sure that he’ll win, somehow."

"Hope he’ll figure it out then, before it’s too late."

"I’ll report when I get there."

Caul

Sporadic snowflakes dotted the air, flowing through the gentle breeze. One moved about in organic patterns of swirls, avoiding the trees around, until it fell onto the deep layer of snow covering the ground.

There were tracks in the snow. They roughly denoted, where, in different weather conditions, a road might lie. The tracks were becoming softer, as the light snowfall layered on. With nightfall, they might become indiscernible. The source of the tracks was further ahead, deeper into the forest, cloaked in warm clothes and a wide-brimmed black hat.

She arrived at a clearing in the woods, but she did not find what she had expected. Covered with a layer of snow, were heaps of rubble and charred stones and support beams. Pieces of collapsed roof lay about, and the last wall still standing was licked by fire, in large black strands.

Her stomach growled. She turned around, and slowly retraced her steps, through the cold afternoon.

It was dark, when she pushed open the door of an inn, in a nearby village. The fireplace was blazing, and there were a few guests still eating and drinking. She sat down close to the fire, took off her backpack, and started unwrapping the layers of wet and sweated through clothes. She spread the worst offenders out, and put her hat on the table next to her.

A woman approached her.

"What can we do for you, ma’am?," the girl asked.

"How much for a night and a meal?"

The girl did some quick math in her head.

"2 gold and 8 parts, ma’am," she answered.

The witch took a bag out of her backpack, and browsed through an eclectic assortment of coins, looking for something close enough. She found a gold coin from this region, and another

that wasn’t, but was a bit bigger in size. Then an assortment of 10 silver coins. She handed them over to the girl, who looked them over.

"A moment, ma’am," she said, and hurried off with the money.

She came back a while later.

"May I take you to your room?"

"I’d prefer to have the meal, here, first. Thank you."

"Of course, ma’am."

The witch leaned back in her chair, and looked into the dancing fire, enjoying the feeling of heat spreading through her limbs.

She must have dozed off for a moment, because a gentle prodding from the woman from earlier jolted her awake. The food was ready. She thanked for it. It was rabbit stew with some vegetables and potatoes floating about. She gobbled up the warm meal, feeling her insides welcome the temperature.

As she was gathering up her things, she asked the woman: "There was a hut, not too far from here, out in the forest. Do you know what happened to it?"

"The witch’s house?"

"Witch?"

"Oh yeah. An old witch used to live there. A woman who used magic. Fortunately, the nearby church order got word about it, and took the woman away. But I wouldn’t go anywhere near that house, if I were you, ma’am. I heard stories of weird noises coming from there. I think she cursed the place."

"Thank you for the warning. Could you show me to my room?"

"Yes, ma’am."

The rays of the sun peeked in through the window. The heap of covers and blankets on the bed moved, grumpily. As from a cocoon, the witch emerged, into the cool air outside the safety of her bed. Clothes came on quickly, trying to escape the thermal shock. Last came the hat, and the backpack.

Stepping out of the warm inn, into the winter landscape beyond felt like a slap in the face. She recoiled slightly, but trudged on, through the snow and cold.

It was a sunny day, not a single cloud in sight. She arrived back at the ruined hut, and stepped onto its premises. She rummaged in the snow, finding some pieces of broken dishes, or shards of once-molten glass. She stepped in the middle of the house, and held her arms outstretched, then released a wave of heat. The snow around her melted into puddles, some

streaming down the blackened wall, making grey lines in the char. A couple of smaller pieces of glass lit up with a glow, but quickly cooled down.

There was a sound from the edge of the property. A metallic tone and rustling. She looked over, and saw a bent, broken cauldron, shaking in a pile of rubble.

"Caul!," she yelped.

She ran up towards the cauldron, and started moving some heavier rocks off of it. Eventually, she cleared enough to pull it out. It was terribly bent and cracked in multiple places, had a deep tear going through it, over the lion face molded on its front. One of its paw shaped legs was missing, and another was hanging on by a thread.

She stepped back to look at it wholly. It hobbled towards her, but stopped, in pain.

"This might hurt a bit. Be brave," she said, and focused.

She slowly raised her hand, and the spots with dents started glowing lightly. Then she pulled a fist, and slammed it down. A strong gust of wind entered the cauldron, and drastically expanded, pushing the dents out. The cauldron fell over, and laid still. She sat down next to it, and pet it gently.

The sun was high above them, before Caul came to again. It wiggled it’s legs, and then heaved itself, until the rocking motion let it get back on its legs. It shook itself, then looked at the witch.

She averted her gaze from it. "Glad you’re better. I’m sorry for the pain." She looked it back, in its eye. "I’m going to look for Francine."

Caul hopped up, at those words, but, stiffened up in pain.

"I need to get you out of here. It might not be too safe, for much longer. Can you walk?"

Caul took a step, and another, then collapsed on the ground.

"I understand. I’ll get you deeper into the forest. Wait there for me."

She lifted her hand, and Caul flew up, into the air. She floated it over to herself, and let it rest on top of her backpack. She kept her focus on it, she wouldn’t have been able to lift its whole weight otherwise. She started moving across the treeline, into the depths of the woods.

After finding a small grotto, in which she left Caul, she made her way back into town. A friendly, helpful pointer later, she was en route towards the order. They have build an encampment,

with some rudimentary walls, and a chapel at its center, not too far from this village.

The main gate was open for anyone. There was a bustle of people inside, some just loitering around, most working on some sort of construction. She stepped up to one of the people that seemed to not have too much to do.

"Hey, boy," she said, "What is all this fuss about?"

"We're building up a school."

"A school? Here in the middle of nowhere?"

"You're not from here, are you, ma'am?" He eyed her over. "We're about in the middle between Brunswick, Clairvaux and Niderhagen. We've settled here to spread the word of the Gods to all of them. The school will help us help all those communities, the same way the chapel has."

"Oh, you're not from here, either?," she asked him.

"I've come from the capital three months ago, with the first mission hereto. But I'll stay. I will be from here. This will be my home. And as soon as the books come over from the capital, I can start teaching children from these backwards places the word of the Gods."

"You've been here, then. I heard there was a witch that your order unveiled, recently. I was told she was taken here. Do you know where she is?"

"Do not worry, ma'am. We have long taken care of that witch. She will no longer hurt anyone. Her magic was purified away in the fire of the pyre she was burned on. No magic will invade this area anymore. Not as long as the church is here."

She stepped back, hearing this, and nearly stumbled. The boy, the teacher, caught her, and helped her up, again.

"Where are you from, ma'am?," he asked, once they were both again firmly on the ground.

"Chateau Liberté."

"I don't recall the name. It's far away?"

"I travel a lot."

"I hope Osyand watches over you, then."

Walking back she noted the charred sides of one of the poles standing near the main gate. Snow was covering the ground. She felt the cold run a shudder down her spine. She walked up to it, and touched the pole. Francine was gone. Francine suffered. Francine didn't deserve this. The witch set her sights back at the chapel.

She opened the doors to it quietly. There were a few people inside, praying. It was a wooden building, with a wooden altar, and wooden idols. The forests around made wood plentiful. This worked well, for her. Fire for fire.

She walked down the chapel and sat down with the other people inside. Then she focused.

Fire erupted from the bottoms of the walls, instantly enveloping them whole. Panic broke out. People started running towards the exit, and shouting started coming from outside. The witch stood up again, and went up to the altar. She looked it over, and stashed some golden trinkets that were sitting on it. She put her palm on it. Turning back, she snapped her fingers, and the altar exploded in a ball of fire. She looked around the room, and every effigy of the gods that permitted the killing of her friend burst into flames. The tears in her eyes glistened in the raging light. She saw people with buckets of water, running around, trying to put out the building, as she got out. A giant flame burst to the sky, as the ceiling of the chapel collapsed. She looked over to the regenerating skeletal corpse of a building, that was to teach children hate. Some fire jumped over from the chapel, and attached itself to the school. More fire spread out to the walls.

From outside of the encampment the with looked back. At the warm light of the fire, the panic, the shouting. This wouldn’t bring Francine back. And one day, they’d be back, rebuilding and spreading more destruction and hate. But today, the church was alight. Today, they could do no more. Today, they felt how Francine must have, at their hands.

The witch found her way back to the forest, to the cave she left Caul in. She sat down next to it, and hugged it.

"She isn’t coming back."

Caul drooped.

They sat in silence, for a bit.

"I do have something for you, though."

The witch turned to Caul, and looked over the broken paw, that was still barely attached.

"I’ve heard of this kind of magic, on my travels. It’s a reminder of what we’ve gone through, but also a reminder, that we withstood it. We survive. We carry the memory of those who helped us. We hold our history in us."

Caul wiggled.

The witch took some of the trinkets she had helped herself to. With a bit of focus, pressure and heat, she melded the

paw back in place with the gold. Some more, gold, and she filled the tear in Caul’s face, and some cracks here and there. Caul tried stepping on the newly healed paw. Then hopped. Then ran in a circle around her. And cuddled into her.

"I’ll take you somewhere safe. I’m sorry I wasn’t there to save her."